

Moving to the big boys, A. Lange & Söhne's 1815 UP/DOWN approaches the experience differently, placing a power-reserve indication on the dial. These are complications with a real-world use case and purpose. They encourage the owner to interact with the watch and make the daily business of winding part of its appeal.

For a more sporty expression, I would look closely at how the case and bracelet work together. Vacheron Constantin's steel Historiques 222 — a personal favourite — measures 37mm across and 7.95mm thick. The integrated bracelet is central to its identity. Try such watches properly adjusted instead of letting an oversized bracelet distort the impression. Check the clasp, the articulation of the links, and the way the watch settles when your arm is resting on a desk. An attractive silhouette still has to work in motion.

A chronograph introduces a different pleasure. Zenith's Chronomaster Original preserves the compact proportions associated with the A386 while offering a display capable of measuring tenths of a second. There is genuine enjoyment in watching a useful mechanism operate. But the right complication is personal. If a second time zone would be useful every week, that may be a better choice than an elaborate calendar you admire but rarely engage with. I always emphasise with all my clients that a complication should follow interest, not become a benchmark you must include.

The buying process deserves the same attention as the watch. With a pre-owned piece, establish its condition, authenticity, and service history before discussing how desirable the reference might be. Ask what has been replaced and whether the dial, hands, and bracelet are correct for the example being offered. A box and papers are useful supporting material, but they should never replace a competent inspection. When the answers are vague, slowing down is usually more sensible than negotiating harder.

> "Some of the most appealing contemporary pieces understand restraint exceptionally well."

I would also resist building a collection around an imaginary future buyer. Taste changes and so can demand. There is little pleasure in owning something you are afraid to wear because every mark feels consequential. Decide what you can comfortably spend, leave room for maintenance, and take your time. The accompanying selection is deliberately varied in construction and personality. It is an invitation to compare what each watch offers, not a prescription to buy all 10.

A satisfying collection should have evidence of your own judgement. A familiar name, an unexpected dial, a beautifully shaped case or a mechanism that keeps drawing you back. Learn enough to understand those choices, then and enjoy it. That, after all, is the part of collecting that cannot be done on your behalf. ■



Clockwise from top: Tom Hiddleston wore a Ralph Lauren Vintage 67 Opalin Silver watch at the New York premiere of *Tenzing;* at the 68th Grammy Awards, Jamie Foxx sported a Jacob & Co. Bugatti Chiron Tourbillon

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